reader II

Maravilloso Reading Group

If we build politically by virtue of the vulnerability of our bodies, then we have to recognize the vulnerability of the body as something indisputable.

1

El Inicio / The Beginning and selected quotes
from Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia

2

This is Not Miami from This is Not Miami by
Fernanda Melchor

5
The Dirty Kid from Things We Lost in the Fire
by Mariana Enríquez

13

Bad Girls by Camila Sosa Villada

[...]

p. 115 (Saviano)

For some reason one stupidly thinks a criminal act has to be more thought out, more deliberate than an innocuous one. But there's really no difference. Actions know an elasticity that ethical judgements ignore.

p.86 (Mignolo, 2003b,2)

The power relation marked by colonial difference and established by the coloniality of power (that is the discourse that justifies colonial difference) is what reveals that knowledge, like economics, is organized according to centers of power and subaltern regions. The trap is that the discourse of modernity created the illusion that knowledge is dis-embodied and de-localized, and that it is necessary for all parts of the plant to "ascent to" the epistemology of modernity.

p. 115

[Violence seen] through an iridescent mist, deodorized, scented indeed, with all its essential cruelties tactfully hidden away (Davis, 2002, 1). Now these practices have emerged as an unstoppable force, fused with daily life.
The interweaving of reality and simulacrum has progressed in such a way that it is increasingly harder (of we have been made to believe as much) to distinguish between reality and fiction, since "the more improbable the event, the more familiar the image" (Davis, 2002, 5).

Gore Capitalism by Sayak Valencia
[selected fragments]

p. 187

(...) "naturalizing" the conditions of a particular territory leads to mystification and leaves us in an artificial and resigned position, negating the possibility that our actions might re-shape that supposedly essential "nature" of the place.

p. 82

Through the establishment of hyperconsumption, capitalism—as the sole relational logic on the horizon, both materially and epistemologically—creates a neo-ontology that re-posits the fundamental questions of any subject: Who am I? What is the meaning of my existence? What place do I occupy in the world? Why? The response to these questions is founded on an obsession with consum[tion, combined with the human need to produce, to create and to make (...)

p. 235

This new capitalism appears frightening because it means that anything can happen—and in the most intimate arena: in the body itself. Gore practices horrify us because they are closer and closer to us and we have not been taught how to think about them, and even less so to confront them. "The problem is that no one can afford to think he's not involved. It's not enough to assume that the way you live your life will protect you from every danger" (Saviano, 2008, 91). This unleashed an interminable uncanny effect that violently undermines our ontologies and erases the distinction between imagination and reality. It unleashes the sensation of being inside a house of mirror in which the uncanny repeats and multiplies before our eyes without us ever knowing which of the images is real, or if all of them are.

Esto es Tijuana

The fury of clouds that is the Pacific Ocean.

A dismembered torso strewn across the highway at rush hour. Cigarettes lit in rapid succession. The neon lights of the red-light district, microscopic universes. Arboreal metastasis.

Narcos. Machismo. Silicone Land. Whore-Barbie's Factory. High caliber weapons laughing, cackling. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Leaving and staying at the same time. Finding another way to say that everything is an eternal return. Irrevocable trajectories and irrevocable women. Violence, tedium and the everyday grind: overdrawn on all accounts. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The word *Bienvenidos* laughing in my face. The word *Bienvenidos* meaning every entrance is an exit. Silence stabs. The desert boils. Migrant screams ring out. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Donkey-zebras imitating nostalgia. Shiny new cars. Enraged taxis. The head repeats an atrocious mantra, "open (yourself) up on the inside." Get into the game. See the Fire. Escape constantly and once and for all bet on winning. *Esto es Tijuana.*

Where the questions where, when and why might not exist, the same as the word "never." Where half of the half does not compute. Where *Interminably* is the same as *Now.*

City of *over and over again.* Where the truth is never known. Where all words—including the word incest—portend multiple histories. Where *mi casa es su casa.* Where *su casa no es mi casa.* Where yes, actually, *su casa es mi caza*: I'm on a hunt and your house is my prey. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La línea never frees itself from the metallic serpent on either side.

A *frontera*-woman looks like death and walks with one hand on her revolver. The syringe-man unsuccessfully attempts to fly along the middle of the metal serpent. The transparent and the true. The piercing.

The first and the third world. The border. El bordo. Hell. The other part of the other side. The other side of the other side. The *This* side of the *Other* side. The happy world of disenchantment. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The limit. The perimeter. The edge of the world. He/she/they/what is dragged behind. The shore that licks white, middle-class, civilized culture and brings it to its end. The time bomb that detonates us. San Diego's garage.

The divided sea laughing raucously *entre las olas. Entre Las Solas.* In the waves and in all the women on their own. The grayness. The paradox. *Esto es Tijuana.*

The *copyright* of the end. *Cartel-right.* Gore capitalism. *Hotels, attractions, nightlife, restaurants, weather and border crossing...*

A blind search for combinatorics. Two million possibilities. *Crunchy, spicy and totally addictive-fabulous blends. Depictions of sodomy, bestiality, alternative sexual practices, racial and ethnic stereotypes. This is Tijuana.*

Everything that enters or leaves the city comes from two parts. Everything here leaves in two or more parts. *You can have whatever you can buy.* City of businesses. Virgin girls *for sale.* Affordable prices for foreigners. Luis Donaldo Colosio Acribillado (a.k.a Bullet-Riddled). Música de banda. Morgue. Techno. NAFTA. *Esto es Tijuana.*

La Tía Juana, Tiguana, Tiuana, Teguana, Tiwana, Tijuan, Ticuan, TJ, Tijuas: you can call her whatever you want because Tijuana—like every other word—means nothing and means: "beside the sea."

Esto es *Queerland.* "Aquí empieza la patria / The homeland begins here."

Esto es Tijuana.

At the brink of el bordo, I become blade.

Tijuana is affectionate. Unfathomable. Full of possibilities.

To be in love with a psychopath and to say so with a smile.

You should leave now. This is Tijuana.

It was January and the bitter wind whipped against Paco's bare face as he made his way down Montesinos towards the port gate. It was well past nine and the temperature was still dropping. That afternoon his father had predicted it would fall to as low as twelve degrees overnight, so Paco had thrown on a sweater and two worker shirts before leaving the house: his tropical blood felt even that faint breath of the notorious *norte* wind.

He bought two cochinita pibil tortas outside the Morelos entry gate, then wolfed down two tacos from Doña Almeja's stand: one with papa and chorizo, the other with papa and huevo, or 'buebo', as the lady who served them pronounced it. Paco's shift began at ten and ended at six in the morning, but he was banking on the bad weather forcing them to suspend operations at the terminal. He'd be paid in full anyway, even if he put in only a couple of hours.

The wind prevented any loading and offloading of pallets and containers but it had no bearing on the work of the crew down on Dock 4, who specialized in loading cars for import and export. That night, Paco and the other guys working the night shift would be responsible for assembling and disassembling steel ramps and dragging them towards the haulers – also known as *madrinas*, because they carried the cars they transported in their immense bellies – attaching the ratchet tie-down straps that fasten the vehicles' tyres to the ship, and then reattaching them to the trailers.

They were in luck. The supervisor had announced that there were only nine haulers to load before they'd be allowed to go home.

'We'll be out of here by midnight,' said one of the crew, a man nicknamed El Burro, The Donkey, who had a bulging gut and tattoos running the full length of both arms.

Paco rarely worked Saturday nights but he was so deep in debt that he'd decided to do a few extra shifts to make up for his splurging. As the youngest member of the crew, he was expected to work up in front. The others joked and chatted as they moved from strap to strap. They all had windburn on their faces, but none of them would have lowered himself to mention it, less still to wear a hat or gloves. Paco couldn't believe how rough and calloused the men's hands were – that's what his own hands would look like if he didn't hurry up and finish school, get a degree and carve out a real future for himself, one that didn't depend on the physical strength that, little by little, would desert him.

And so, full of cheer and banter because they wouldn't have to wait until dawn to leave that freezing cold quayside, the men loaded eight haulers. The ninth one, however, still hadn't arrived at the terminal.

'There's been a delay,' the supervisor shouted, to make himself heard over the wind. The last hauler had blown a tyre in Tamarindo, eighty kilometres or so from the port. It was eleven o'clock and bitingly cold.

The dockers decided to sit on the ground, bunched together to protect themselves from the cold, wet wind. They hadn't been resting there fifteen minutes when a blaze of red and blue lit up the darkness engulfing Dock 2.

'I smell trouble,' muttered Chiles, an older man with grey hair and a pot belly. They called him Chiles on account of his last name, which was the same as a famous local brand of tinned chillies.

An immigration van and two pickup trucks packed full of special police officers careered along the esplanade and pulled up next to a small cargo ship moored to Dock 2. A Federal Police car with its siren on was following behind the pickups. The officers jumped down from the truck beds with their rifles raised, some of them holding police dogs by leashes, and boarded the vessel. Paco and his co-workers could make out only the narrow beams of flashlights being shone all over the deck.

'That thing must be packing a shit-ton of drugs,' Paco said, 'The cops must have found...'

But he didn't get to finish his sentence because just then, amid much shouting and swearing, the police returned to the dock with about twenty more people, all of them black, as far as Paco could tell: skeletal men and women who were weeping and rubbing their bare arms and who vanished into the back of the Immigration van. Some of the officers, confused as to why the dogs were still barking at the water, hung back by the side of the dock and shone their flashlights at the space between the ship's hull and the concrete wall, but after a while they also moved on.

By midnight, the port was once again deserted and Paco and his crew were still sitting on the ground awaiting the arrival of the ninth hauler. One o'clock came and went, then one thirty, and it wasn't until past two a.m. that the headlights of the last trailer emerged from the darkness of the terminal. The men made quick work of it and in a matter of minutes they were heading over to the supervisor to ask if they could leave.

'Hang on, boys. I'm just getting clearance,' he said, holding his handheld radio to his mouth as if he were about to eat it. 'Give me an hour and I'll have you out of here.'

Cussing the man and the mother who had him, Paco and the others parked their now frozen, aching backsides on the concrete floor. They entertained themselves talking about women, football, strategies to win the lottery, politics, religion and back to women again. Bored and fed up, Paco let his mind wander as he gazed at the black sea through the gap between two rows of parked haulers. Suddenly he thought he saw something in that narrow space, a shadow gliding down, and he squinted to get a better look. His heart nearly jumped out of his chest when

he finally recognized the outline of a man running towards them. Paco sat bolt upright and the others stopped laughing. For a moment he thought it must be a drifter, a junkie who'd somehow slipped past port security and was coming to mug them, but then he noticed that the man wasn't alone: a handful of equally ragged-looking figures were trailing him. While his fellow dockers got to their feet beside him, Paco counted nine men, nine black men, soaked to the bone with their arms and legs covered in welts that looked like whip marks.

Paco moved towards the intruders with his fists raised, but the man at the front, the tallest among them, held up his open palms.

'My brother! Help me, brother, please, we're begging you!' he exclaimed in a thick Caribbean accent.

'Who are you?' Paco shouted back.

'We're Dominicans,' the man said. 'Please, help us. We haven't eaten for a week.'

'Don't give us away,' the others whimpered in unison.

They were barefoot and stank of diesel and salt water. All of them were young, skinny yet strong, sinewy. They must have been clinging to the pier pilings for two hours, thought Paco, horrified. That's why the immigration police hadn't found them: the women and older ones hadn't been able to escape the hold, so they'd been caught, but these nine, the fittest among the group, the most desperate, had jumped into the water and clung to the barnacle-crusted concrete pillars, pounded by the raging waves and wintry gusts furiously sweeping across the port, until the police finally left.

Paco couldn't believe it.

'Please, tell us we're in Miami...' another Dominican begged.

Paco gave a nervous snicker.

'Miami? You're kidding. You're in Veracruz!'

One of the men let out a sob.

'How much further to Miami?'

'Fucking ages, like three days by boat,' Paco replied.

'And where are we?' another asked. 'Where is Veracruz?'

The Dominicans started to glance furtively at the boat they'd just escaped from, as if trying to work out how to get back on it.

Paco drew the curve of the Gulf of Mexico in the air in front of him, then pointed to a space in the middle.

The Dominicans looked grief-stricken. It occurred to Paco that, if they'd had sufficient liquid in their bodies, they would have broken down and cried like babies.

'And by land, how do we get to Miami?' asked the tallest man, the one who seemed to be the ringleader among the stowaways, the one who'd spoken first.

'I have no idea,' Paco replied. 'The furthest north I've ever been is Poza Rica.'

'Help us, brother. Have mercy,' another moaned.

Nine pairs of enormous, yellowish eyes stared imploringly at the dockers.

'We'd better get these guys to the toilets,' El Burro said at last. 'If anyone sees them, they're fucked.'

They led them to the bathroom in one of the warehouses. Once inside, Paco took out his remaining torta; he knew it wouldn't be enough to feed even one of those poor devils, but their hollow-eyed, emaciated faces were weighing on his conscience.

The ringleader snatched the roll so violently that he nearly took Paco's arm with it. He devoured half of it in two greedy mouthfuls, and on seeing his fellow sufferers staring at him and salivating, he passed what was left of the torta to the closest one, a guy with bloodshot eyes who was dressed in just a T-shirt and some dark, tattered underpants. Another dockworker brought them some fresh water and the Dominicans literally threw themselves at the bucket containing the liquid; they drank with the desperation of people who have spent days at sea seeing nothing but the darkness of the hold, hearing nothing but the thunder of machinery, squeaking rats and the murmurs of their fellow stowaways, who'd spent the whole journey praying that the captain of their vessel wasn't English or German; they'd been warned that some of the European officers were in the habit of tossing stowaways overboard, to spare themselves tiresome paperwork at their destination.

Once they'd all had a drink of water, the Dominicans proceeded to tell the dockworkers their story in hushed voices. A total of thirty of them had boarded the vessel, which was shipping wood from Puerto Plata to Miami. They'd bribed some of the crew to let them hide in the hold. Along the way they counted the stops they'd been told the boat would make: Río Haina, Cristóbal, Veracruz, and they'd got ready to disembark in what they'd believed was the United States. What they didn't know, however, was that they had made an additional stop, in Kingston, before sailing south to Panama.

One of the stowaways, who'd been silent until that point, walked up to Paco, took him by the arm and pulled him aside, a few feet from the group. His face was covered in insect bites.

'Brother, you have to help me. You don't know what I've been through. I have to get to the States. I have a sister there, in New York. She is waiting for me...'

He squeezed Paco's arm with his giant hand and spoke so close to his face that Paco could now clearly see the scars across his cheeks and forehead. Up close, the man's skin wasn't actually black, but closer to the colour of buffed leather, reddish and oily, and the marks covering his face were a lighter shade of brown.

'My sister sent me a letter. She told me the men who killed my father are there. You don't know what I've been through, brother. My father owed people money and they killed him, they killed everyone when my sister and I were heading down to the river to collect water. You don't know what it's like to watch your father being hacked to death with a machete, to watch your mother being raped.'

He howled through clenched teeth.

'They raped and killed her and I couldn't do anything as I hid in the bushes.'

They're cigarette burns, Paco realized to his shock,

unable to take his eyes off the Dominican's scars.

'My sister wrote to me. She said "Those guys are here, in New York," and that's the only reason I'm going. I'm going to kill those sons of bitches. I'm going to hack them to death like they hacked my mami...'

Paco didn't dare say anything. So intense was the stowaway's hatred that Paco suddenly felt scared to go through with the plan that the other dockers and the hauler drivers – who were all still waiting for the green light to leave – had come up with. The idea was to hide the Dominicans inside the cabs of their vehicles and smuggle them out of the port, then let them out somewhere on the highway. This man was full of hatred, of murderous resolve, and nothing and no one was going to stop him. To reach his destination he'd be capable of assaulting, even killing a man, if he hadn't already.

One of Paco's co-workers – a dark-skinned man with curly hair and fine features, who they nicknamed Thalía – rescued Paco from the pockmarked Dominican and led him out of the toilets and over to the quay. The wind had picked up and it smelled of burnt grease from the boats.

'Listen to me, Ojitos. Don't you go giving that fucker your details,' Thalía warned, his mouth practically touching Paco's ear to stop the wind from whipping away his words.

'No way. The guy's a psycho,' Paco replied. He took a cigarette from the pack Thalía held out to him but couldn't get it to light. 'Did you hear what he said to me? He wants us to help get him out, says he's got to go to New York to kill fuck knows who...'

Thalía patted him on the shoulder.

'Look, leave it to the drivers. They'll take them and kick them out somewhere near Puebla...'

'But how can we let them into Mexico?' Paco shot back. 'You don't know they won't kill or rape someone out there...'

In the distance, the hauler engines rumbled into action. One by one, they filed through the facility exit barriers.

'Remember what they say: sometimes even the Devil needs a prayer...'

Paco had never heard that saying before. Knowing Thalía, he'd probably made it up on the spot.

From the other end of the concourse, the supervisor gave them the signal to leave.

As he wandered home down the still slumbering streets, Paco went over the events of the night. It took him a couple of hours to reach his neighbourhood on foot because he saw no point in spending money on a taxi, and as he walked along with his hands buried inside his pockets, the wind finally dropped and the dawn began to reveal itself in the reflection of the windows he passed. Paco spotted a lone little bird chirping away on a parched tree in the park near his house, and he watched as a glossy raven flew down from a nearby cornice and snatched it in mid-flight, before landing on the head of a statue to pluck the bird alive.

Sickened, Paco bent over to try to vomit the torta, Doña Almeja's tacos and the pint of bile that was already halfway up in his throat. But for all his retching, he couldn't bring anything up: his throat had clamped shut. Wiping his brow with the tail of his shirt, he swore to himself that that was the last night shift he would ever work.

My family thinks I'm crazy, and all because I choose to live in our old family home in Constitución, in the house that once belonged to my paternal grandparents. It's an imposing stone building on Calle Virreyes, with iron doors painted green, art deco details, and old mosaics on a floor so worn out that if I ever got the urge to wax it I could open up a roller rink. But I was always in love with this house. I remember when I was little and my family rented it out to a law firm and I got so upset; I missed those rooms with their tall windows, and the walled patio that was like a secret garden. I hated not being able to just go in anytime I wanted. I never really missed my grandfather, a silent man who hardly ever smiled and never played—I didn't cry when he died. I cried a lot, though, when after he died we lost the house for several years.

After the law firm a team of dentists moved in, and then the house was rented to a travel magazine that folded in less than two years. The house was beautiful and comfortable and in remarkably good condition considering how old it was, but by then no one, or very few people, wanted to settle in that neighborhood. The travel magazine went for it only because the rent was very low. But not even that could save them from promptly going bankrupt, and it certainly didn't help that their offices were robbed: all their computers were stolen, plus a microwave oven and even a heavy photocopier.

The Constitución station is where trains coming from the south of the country enter the city. In the nineteenth century, the port's aristocracy had lived in Constitución; that's why houses like my family's exist, and there are plenty of others that have been converted into hotels or old folks' homes, or are crumbling to the ground on the other side of the station, in Barracas. In 1887, the aristocratic families fled to the northern part of the city to escape the yellow fever. Few of them came back, almost none. Over the years, families of rich businessmen like my grandfather were able to buy those stone houses with their gargoyles and bronze door knockers. But the neighborhood was marked by that flight, the abandonment, the condition of being unwanted.

And it's only getting worse.

But if you know how to move around the neighborhood, if you understand its dynamics, its schedules, it isn't dangerous. Or it's less dangerous. I know that on Friday nights, if I go down to Plaza Garay I might end up caught in a fight between several possible adversaries: the mini-narcos from Calle Ceballos who defend their territory from invaders and chase down the countless people who owe them money; the brain-dead addicts who get offended at anything and react by lashing out with broken bottles; the drunk and tired transvestites who have their own patches of pavement to defend. I also know that if I walk home along the avenue I'm more exposed to muggers than if I take Solís, even though the avenue is well lit and Solís is dark; most of the few streetlights it has are broken. You have to know the neighborhood to learn these strategies. I've been robbed twice on the avenue, both times by kids who ran past and grabbed my bag and pushed me to the ground. The first time, I filed a police report; by the second I knew it was pointless. The police let teenage muggers rob on the avenue as far as the highway bridge—three free blocks—in exchange for favors. There are certain tricks to being able to move easily in this neighborhood and I've mastered them perfectly, though sure, something unexpected can always happen. It's a question of not being afraid, of making a few necessary friends, saying hi to the neighbors even if they're criminals—especially if they're criminals—of walking with your head high, paying attention.

I like the neighborhood. No one understands why, but I do: it makes me feel sharp and audacious, on my toes. There aren't many places like Constitución left in the city; except for the slums on its outskirts, the rest of the city is richer and friendlier—huge and intense but easy to live in. Constitución isn't easy, and it's beautiful: all those once-luxurious alcoves, like abandoned temples now occupied by unbelievers who don't even know that inside those walls hymns to old gods once rang out.

There are also a lot of people who live on the street. Not as many as in Plaza Congreso, two kilometers from my front door—over there it's a regular encampment, right in front of the government buildings, scrupulously ignored but also so visible that every night squads of volunteers come to hand out food, check the children's health, distribute blankets in winter and fresh water in summer. The homeless in Constitución are more neglected, and help rarely reaches them. Across from my house is a corner with a shuttered convenience store, whose doors and windows are bricked up to keep occupiers out; a young woman lives with her son on the sidewalk in front of it. She's pregnant, maybe a few months along, although you never know with the junkie mothers in the neighborhood because they're so thin. The son must be around five years old. He doesn't go to school and he spends his days on the subway, begging for money in exchange for prayer cards of Saint Expeditus. I know because I've seen him at night, on the train, on my way home from the city center. He has a disturbing method: after offering the prayer cards to the passengers, he obliges them to shake hands, a brief and very grimy squeeze. The passengers have to contain their pity and disgust: the kid is very dirty and he stinks. Anyway, I never saw anyone compassionate enough to take him out of the subway, bring him home, give him a bath, call social services. People shake his hand, buy his prayer cards. His forehead is always wrinkled into a frown, and when he talks, his voice is shot; he tends to have a cold, and sometimes he smokes with other

kids from the subway or around Constitución.

One night, we walked together from the subway station to my house. He didn't talk to me, but we kept each other company. I asked him some dumb questions, his age, his name; he didn't answer. He wasn't a sweet or innocent child. When I reached the door of my house, though, he said good-bye.

"Bye, neighbor," he said.

"Bye, neighbor," I replied.

THE DIRTY KID AND HIS MOTHER sleep on three mattresses so worn out that, piled up, they're the same height as a normal bed. The mother keeps what little clothing she has in several black garbage bags, and she has a backpack full of other things; I couldn't say what they are. She doesn't move from the corner; she stays there and begs for money in a gloomy and monotonous voice. I don't like the mother. Not just because she's irresponsible, or because she smokes crack and the ash burns her pregnant belly, or because I never once saw her treat her son, the dirty kid, with kindness. There's something else I don't like. I told my friend Lala while she was cutting my hair in her house one Monday, a holiday. Lala is a hairdresser, but she hasn't worked in a salon for a long time; she doesn't like to have bosses, she says. She earns more money and is more at ease in her apartment. As a salon, Lala's place has a few issues. The hot water, for example, only flows sporadically because the heater is busted, and sometimes, when she's washing my hair after dyeing it, I get a shock of cold water over my head that makes me cry out. Then she rolls her eyes and explains that all the plumbers cheat her, they charge her too much, they never come back. I believe her.

"Girl, that woman is a monster," she yells as she burns my scalp with her ancient hair dryer. It also hurts a little when her thick fingers smooth my hair. Lala decided to be a Brazilian woman years ago, but she was born a Uruguayan man. Now she's the best transvestite stylist in the neighborhood and she doesn't work the streets anymore; faking a Brazilian accent was useful in seducing men when she was hooking, but it doesn't really make sense now. Still, she's so used to it that sometimes she talks on the phone in Portuguese, or she gets mad and raises her arms to the sky and begs for vengeance or mercy from Pomba Gira, her personal spirit, to whom she has a small altar set up in the corner of the room where she cuts hair. It's right next to her computer, which is always lit up in a perpetual chat.

"So you think she's a monster too."

"She gives me the chills, *mami*. It's like she's cursed or something, I don't know."

"Why do you say that?"

"I'm not saying anything. But around here the word is she'll do anything for money. She even goes to witches' sabbats."

"Oh, Lala, what witches? There's no such thing as witches. You shouldn't believe everything you hear."

She gives my hair a yank that seems intentional, but then she apologizes. It was intentional.

"What do you know about what *really* goes on around here, *mamita*? You live here, but you're from a different world."

She's right, even though I don't like to hear it. Nor do I like that she can so candidly put me right in my place: the middle-class woman who thinks she's a rebel because she chose to live in the most dangerous neighborhood in Buenos Aires. I sigh.

"You're right, Lala. But I mean, she lives in front of my house and she's always there, on the mattresses. She never moves."

"You work long hours, you don't know what she does. You don't watch her at night, either. The people in this neighborhood, *mami*, they're really . . . what's the word? You don't even realize and they attack you."

"Stealthy?"

"That's it. You've sure got a vocabulary on you. Doesn't she, Sarita? Real high class, this one."

Sarita has been waiting around fifteen minutes for Lala to finish my hair, but she doesn't mind. She's leafing through magazines. Sarita is a very young transvestite who works the streets above Solís, and she's beautiful.

"Tell her, Sarita, tell her what you told me."

But Sarita pouts her lips like a silent-movie diva; she doesn't feel like telling me anything. It's better that way. I don't want to hear the neighborhood horror stories, which are all unthinkable and plausible at the same time and don't scare me a bit. At least not during the day. At night, if I'm up late to finish a project, and everything is silent so I can concentrate, sometimes I recall the stories they tell in low voices. And I check to be sure the front door is good and locked, and the door to the balcony, too. And sometimes I stand there looking out at the street, especially at the corner where the dirty kid is sleeping beside his mom, both completely still, like nameless dead.

ONE NIGHT AFTER DINNER, the doorbell rang. Strange: almost no one comes to see me at that hour. Only Lala, on nights when she feels lonely and we stay up together listening to sad *rancheras* and drinking whiskey. When I looked out the window to see who it was—no one opens the door right away in this neighborhood, especially when it's nearly midnight—I saw the dirty kid standing there. I ran to get the keys and let him in. He'd been crying; you could tell from the clean streaks down his grubby face. He came running in, but he stopped before he got to the dining room door, as if he needed my permission. Or as if he were afraid to keep going.

"What's wrong?" I asked.

"My mom didn't come back," he said.

His voice was less hoarse now, but he didn't sound like a five-year-old child.

"She left you alone?"

He nodded.

"Are you scared?"

"I'm hungry," he replied. He was scared, too, but he was already hardened and wouldn't acknowledge it in front of a stranger. One who, moreover, had a house, a beautiful and enormous house right there beside his little piece of concrete.

"OK," I told him. "Come on."

He was barefoot. The last time I'd seen him, he'd been wearing some fairly new running shoes. Had he taken them off in the heat? Or had someone stolen them in the night? I didn't want to ask. I sat him down on a kitchen chair and put a little chicken and rice into the oven. While we waited, I spread cheese on some delicious homemade bread. He ate while looking me in the eyes, very seriously, calmly. He was hungry, but not starved.

"Where did your mom go?"

He shrugged.

"Does she leave you alone a lot?"

He shrugged again. I felt like shaking him, and right away I was ashamed. He needed my help; there was no reason for him to satisfy my morbid curiosity. And even so, something about his silence made me angry. I wanted him to be a friendly, charming boy, not this sullen, dirty kid who ate his chicken and rice slowly, savoring every bite, and belched after finishing his glass of Coca-Cola. This he did drink greedily, and then he asked for more. I didn't have anything to give him for dessert, but I knew the ice cream parlor over on the avenue would be open; in summer they served until after midnight. I asked him if he wanted to go, and he said yes with a smile that changed his face completely. He had small teeth, and one on the bottom was about to fall out. I was a little scared to go out so late, and to the avenue, no less. But the ice cream shop tended to be neutral territory; you almost never heard of muggings or fights there.

I didn't bring my purse. Instead I stuffed a little money in the pocket of my jeans. In the street, the dirty kid gave me his hand, and not with the indifference he had when he greeted the people on the subway who bought his prayer cards. He held on tight—maybe he was still scared. We crossed the street, and I saw that the mattress where he slept beside his mother was still empty. The backpack wasn't there, either; she had taken it, or someone had stolen it when they found it there without its owner.

We had to walk three blocks to the ice cream parlor and I decided to take Ceballos, a strange street that could be silent and calm on some nights. The less chiseled transvestites worked there, the chubbiest and oldest ones. I was sorry not to have any shoes to put on the dirty kid's feet. The sidewalks often had shards of glass from broken bottles, and I didn't want him to get hurt. But he walked confidently and seemed used to going barefoot. That night the three blocks were almost empty of transvestites, but they were full of altars. I remembered what they were celebrating: it was January 8, the day of Gauchito Gil, a popular saint from the provinces of Corrientes who has devotees all over the country. He's especially beloved in poor neighborhoods, though you'll see altars all over the city, even in cemeteries. Antonio Gil, it's said, was murdered at the end of the nineteenth century for being a deserter. A policeman killed him, hanged him from a tree and slit his throat. But before he died, the outlaw gaucho told the policeman: "If you want your son to get better, you must pray for me." The policeman did, because his son was very sick. And the boy got better. Then the policeman went back, took Antonio Gil down from the tree, and gave him a proper burial. The place where he had bled to death became a shrine that still exists today, and thousands of people visit it every summer.

I found myself telling the dirty kid the story of the miraculous gaucho, and we stopped in front of one of the altars. There was the plaster saint, with his blue shirt and the red bandanna around his neck—a red headband, too—and a cross on his back, also red. There were many red cloths and a small red flag: the color of blood, in memory of the injustice and the slit throat. But there was nothing macabre or sinister about it. The gaucho brings luck, he cures people, he helps them and doesn't ask them for much in return, just these tributes and sometimes a little alcohol. People make pilgrimages to the Mercedes sanctuary in Corrientes in fifty-degree heat; the pilgrims come on foot, by bus, on horseback, and from all over, even Patagonia. The candles around him made him wink in the half-dark. I lit one that had gone out and then used the flame to light a cigarette. The dirty kid seemed uneasy.

"We're going to the ice cream shop now," I told him. But that wasn't it.

"The gaucho is good," he said. "But the other one isn't."

He said it in a quiet voice, looking at the candles.

"What other one?" I asked.

"The skeleton," he said. "There are skeletons back there."

Around the neighborhood, "back there" always means the other side of the station, past the platforms, where the tracks and the embankment disappear southward. Back there, you often see shrines to saints a little less friendly than Gauchito Gil. I know that Lala goes there to bring offerings to Pomba Gira, colored plates and chickens she buys at the supermarket because she can't get up the nerve to kill one herself. She only goes as far as the embankment, and only during the day, because it can be dangerous. And she told me that "back there" she's seen a lot of shrines to San la Muerte, the skeleton saint of death, with his red and black candles.

"But death's not a bad saint, either," I told the dirty kid, who looked at me with widened eyes as if I were saying something crazy. "He's a saint that can do bad things if people ask him to, but most people don't ask for evil things; they ask for protection.

Does your mother bring you back there?" I asked him.

"Yes. But sometimes I go alone," he replied. And then he tugged at my arm to urge me on toward the ice cream shop.

It was really hot. The sidewalk in front of the shop was sticky from so many ice cream cones dripping onto it. I thought about the dirty kid's bare feet, now with all this new grime. He went running in and his old-man's voice asked for a large ice cream with two scoops, chocolate and dulce de leche with chocolate chips. I didn't order anything. The heat took away my appetite, and I was worried about what I should do with the boy if his mother didn't turn up. Bring him to the police station? To a hospital? Let him stay at my house until she came back? Did this city even have anything like social services? There was a number to call in winter to report someone living on the street who was suffering too much from the cold. But that was pretty much all I knew. I realized, while the dirty kid was licking his sticky fingers, how little I cared about people, how natural these desperate lives seemed to me.

When the ice cream was gone, the dirty kid got up from the bench we'd been sitting on and went walking toward the corner where he lived with his mother, practically ignoring me. I followed him. The street was very dark; the electricity had gone out, as often happened on very hot nights. But I could see him clearly in the headlights of the cars. He was also lit, him and his now completely black feet, by the candles in the makeshift shrines. We reached the corner without him taking my hand again or saying a word to me.

His mother was on the mattress. Like all addicts she had no notion of temperature, and she was wearing a thick coat with the hood up, as if it were raining. Her enormous belly was bare, her shirt too short to cover it. The dirty kid greeted her and sat down on the mattress. She said nothing to him.

When she saw me, she was rabid. She ran at me snarling, there's no other way to describe the sound she made. She reminded me of my dog when it broke its hip and went mad with the pain, when it stopped whining and would only growl.

"Where did you take him, you fucking bitch? What do you want with him, huh? Huh? Don't you even think about touching my son!"

She was so close I could see every one of her teeth. I could see that her gums were bleeding, her lips burned by the pipe, and I could smell the tar on her breath.

"I bought him an ice cream," I shouted at her, but I retreated when I saw she had a broken bottle in her hand and was ready to attack me with it.

"Get out of here or I'll cut you, you fucking bitch!"

The dirty kid was staring at the ground as if nothing were happening, as if he didn't know us, not his mother or me. I was furious with him. *Ungrateful little brat*, I thought, and I took off running. I went into my house as fast as I could, though my hands were shaking and I had trouble finding the key. I turned on all the lights—luckily the electricity hadn't gone out on my block. I was afraid the mother might send someone after me to beat me up. Who knew what could be going through her head, or what kinds of friends she had in the neighborhood. I didn't know anything about her. After a while, I went up to the second floor and looked out from the balcony. She was lying there faceup, smoking a cigarette. The dirty kid was next to her and it looked like he was sleeping. I went to bed with a book and a glass of water, but I couldn't read or pay attention to the TV. The heat seemed more intense with the fan on; it only stirred the hot air and drowned out the noise from outside.

In the morning, I forced myself to have breakfast before I went to work. The heat was already suffocating and the sun was barely up. When I closed the door, the first thing I noticed was the absence of the mattress on the corner in front of my house. There was nothing left of the dirty kid or his mother, not a bag or a stain on the pavement or even a cigarette butt. Nothing. Like they'd never even been there.

The body turned up a week after the dirty kid and his mother disappeared. When I came back from work, my feet swollen from the heat, dreaming only of the coolness of my house with its high ceilings and large rooms that not even the most hellish summer could heat up entirely, I found the whole block gone crazy. Three police cars, yellow tape cordoning off a crime scene, and a lot of people crowded just outside its perimeter. It wasn't hard to pick Lala out from the crowd, with her white high heels and gold bun. She was so agitated she'd forgotten to put the false lashes on her right eye and her face looked asymmetrical, almost paralyzed on one side.

"What happened?"

"They found a little kid."

"Dead?"

"Worse. Decapitated! Do you have cable, sweets?"

Lala's cable had been cut off months ago because she hadn't paid the bill. We went into my house and lay on the bed to watch TV, with the ceiling fan spinning dangerously fast and the balcony window open so we could hear if anything interesting happened out on the street. I set a tray on the bed with a pitcher of cold orange juice, and Lala commandeered the remote control. It was strange to see our neighborhood on the screen, to hear the journalists out the window as they dashed back and forth, to look out and see the vans from all the different stations. It was strange to decide to wait for the TV to give us details about the crime, but we knew the neighborhood's dynamics well: no one was going to talk, they wouldn't tell the truth, at least not for the first few days. Silence first, in case any of the people involved in the crime deserved loyalty. Even if it was a horrible child murder. First, mouths shut. In a few weeks the stories would start. Now it was the TV's moment.

Early on, around eight o'clock, when Lala and I were at the start of a long night that began with orange juice, continued with pizza and beer, and ended with whiskey—I opened a bottle

my father had given me—information was scarce. In a deserted parking lot on Calle Solís, a dead child had turned up. Decapitated. They'd found the head to one side of the body.

By ten o'clock, we knew that the head was skinned to the bone and that the scalp hadn't been found on the scene. Also, the eyelids had been sewn shut and the tongue bitten, though they didn't know whether by the dead boy himself or—and this brought a shriek from Lala—by someone else's teeth.

The news programs continued with information all night long, journalists working in shifts, reporting live from the street. The police, as usual, didn't say anything in front of the cameras, but they supplied constant information to the press.

At midnight, no one had claimed the body. It was also known by then that the boy had been tortured: the torso was covered in cigarette burns. They suspected a sexual assault, which was confirmed around two in the morning, when the first forensics report was leaked.

And at that hour, still, no one was claiming the body. No family members. Not a mother or a father or brothers or sisters or uncles or cousins or neighbors or acquaintances. No one.

The decapitated boy, said the TV, was between five and seven years old. It was difficult to calculate because when he was alive he'd been undernourished.

"I want to see him," I told Lala.

"You're crazy! How could they show a decapitated boy? Why would you want to see him? You're morbid. You've always been a little freak, the morbid countess in her palace on Virreyes."

"Lala, I think I know him."

"You know who, the child?"

I said yes and started to cry. I was drunk, but I was also sure that the dirty kid was now the decapitated kid. I told Lala about our encounter the night he'd rung my doorbell. Why didn't I take care of him, why didn't I figure out how to take him away from his mother, why didn't I at least give him a bath? I have a big old beautiful tub and I barely ever use it, I just take quick showers, and only every once in a while do I enjoy an actual bath . . . why didn't I at least wash the dirt off him? And, I don't know, buy him a rubber duck and one of those wands to blow bubbles and let him play? I could easily have bathed him, and then we could have gone for ice cream. Yes, it was late, but there are big supermarkets in the city that never close and they sell tennis shoes, and I could have bought him a pair. How could I have let him walk around barefoot, at night, on these dark streets? I should never have let him go back to his mother. When she threatened me with the bottle I should have called the police, and they'd have thrown her in jail and I'd have kept the boy or helped him get adopted by a family who'd love him. But no. I got mad at him for being ungrateful, for not defending me from his mother! I got mad at a terrified child, son of an addict, a five-year-old boy who lives on the street!

Who *lived* on the street, because now he's dead, decapitated!

Lala helped me throw up in the toilet, and then she went out to buy pills for my headache. I vomited from drunkenness and fear and also because I was sure it was him, the dirty kid, raped and decapitated in a parking lot. And for what?

"Why did they do this to him, Lala?" I asked, curled up in her strong arms, back in bed again, both of us slowly smoking early-morning cigarettes.

"Princess, I don't know if it's really your kid they killed, but we'll go to the DA's office once it's open, so you can get some peace."

"You'll go with me?"

"Of course."

"But why, Lala, why would they do such a thing?"

Lala crushed out her cigarette on a plate next to the bed and poured herself another glass of whiskey. She mixed it with Coca-Cola and stirred it with a finger.

"I don't think it's your boy. The one they killed . . . They had no pity. It's a message for someone."

"A narco's revenge?"

"Only the narcos kill like that."

We were silent. I was scared. There were narcos in Constitución? Like the ones that shocked me when I read about Mexico, ten headless bodies hanging from a bridge, six heads thrown from a car onto the steps of the parliament building, a common grave with seventy-three bodies, some decapitated, others missing arms? Lala smoked in silence and set the alarm. I decided to skip work so I could go straight to the DA and report everything I knew about the dirty kid.

In the morning, my head still pounding, I made coffee for us both, Lala and me. She asked to use the bathroom. I heard her turn on the shower and I knew she'd be in there at least an hour. I turned on the TV again. The newspaper had no new information. I wasn't going to find anything online, either—the web would only be a boiling cauldron of rumors and insanity.

The morning news said that a woman had come in to claim the decapitated boy. A woman named Nora, who had come to the morgue with a newborn baby in her arms and accompanied by some other family members. When I heard that about the "newborn baby" my heart pounded in my chest. It was definitely the dirty kid, then. The mother hadn't gone sooner for the body because—what a terrible coincidence—the night of the crime had been the night she gave birth. It made sense. The dirty kid had been left alone while his mother delivered and then . . .

Then what? If it was a message, if it was revenge, it couldn't be directed at that poor woman who had slept in front of my house so many nights, that addict girl who couldn't be much older than twenty. Maybe at his father: that's it, his father. Who could the dirty kid's father be?

But then the cameras went crazy, the cameramen running, the journalists out of breath, everyone surging toward the

woman coming out of the DA's office. "Nora, Nora," they yelled. "Who could have done this to Nachito?"

"His name is Nacho," I whispered.

And then there she was on the screen, Nora, a close-up of her sobbing and wailing. And it wasn't the dirty kid's mother. It was a completely different woman. A woman around thirty years old, already graying, dark-skinned and very fat—surely the kilos she'd put on with the pregnancy. Almost the opposite of the dirty kid's mother.

It was impossible to make out what she was shouting. She was falling down. Someone, probably a sister, supported her from behind. I changed channels, but they were all showing that wailing woman, until a policeman got between the microphones and her sobs, and a patrol car appeared to take her away. There was a lot of news. I told it all to Lala, sitting on the toilet while she shaved, fixed her makeup, pulled her hair into a neat bun.

"His name is Ignacio. Nachito. And the family had reported him missing on Sunday, but when they saw what was happening on TV, they didn't think it was their son because this boy, Nachito, disappeared in Castelar. They're from Castelar."

"But that's so far away! How did he end up here? Ay, princess, what a fright this all is. I'm canceling all my appointments, it's decided. You can't cut hair after this."

"His belly button was sewn shut, too."

"Whose, the child's?"

"Yes. It seems they tore off his ears, too."

"Princess, no one's ever getting to sleep again around here, I'm telling you. We may be criminals, but this is satanic."

"That's what they're saying. That it's satanic. No, not satanic. They say it was a sacrifice, an offering to San la Muerte."

"Save us, Pomba Gira! Save us, Maria Padilha!"

"Last night I told you the boy talked to me about San la Muerte. It's not him, Lala, but he knew." Lala kneeled in front of me and stared at me with her big dark eyes.

"You, my dear, aren't going to say a word about this. Nothing. Not to the police or anyone. I was crazy last night to think of letting you talk to the judge. Not a word about any of it. We're silent as a grave, pardon the expression."

I listened to her. She was right. I didn't have anything to say, nothing to report. Just a nighttime walk with a boy from the street who disappeared, as street kids often do. Their parents change neighborhoods and take them along. They join groups of child thieves or windshield washers on the avenue, or they become drug mules; when they're being used to sell drugs, they have to change neighborhoods often. Or they set up camp in subway stations. Street kids are never in one place for long; they can stay for a while, but they always leave. Sometimes they run away from their parents. Or they vanish because some distant uncle turns up and takes pity on them and brings them home with him far away in the south, to live in a house on a dirt road and share a room with five other kids, but at least there's a roof over their heads. It wasn't strange, not at all, that the mother and child had disappeared from one day to the next. The parking lot where the decapitated boy had appeared was not on the route the dirty kid and I had taken that night. And the part about San la Muerte? Coincidence. Lala said the neighborhood was full of people who worshipped San la Muerte. All the Paraguayan immigrants and transplants from Corrientes were followers of the saint, but that didn't make them murderers. Lala worshipped Pomba Gira, who looks like a demonic woman, with horns and trident. Did that make her a satanic killer?

It did not.

"I want you to stay with for me a few days, Lala."

"But of course, princess. I'll ready my chambers."

Lala loved my house. She liked to put on music very loud and slowly descend the stairs wearing a turban and holding a cigarette: a femme fatale. "I'm Josephine Baker," she'd say, and then she would complain about being the only transvestite in Constitución who had the faintest idea who Josephine Baker was. "You can't imagine how rough these new girls are, ignorant and empty as a drainpipe. They get worse and worse. It's hopeless."

It was hard to walk around the neighborhood with the same confidence I'd had before the crime. Nachito's murder had an almost narcotic effect on that area of Constitución. At night you didn't hear fighting anymore, and the dealers had moved a few blocks south. There were too many cops watching the place where they'd found the body. Which, said the newspapers and the investigators, had not been the scene of the crime. Someone had dumped him there in the old parking lot, already dead.

On the corner where the dirty kid and his mom used to sleep, the neighbors set up a shrine to the Headless Boy, as they now called him. And they put up a photo with a caption that said *Justice for Nachito.* In spite of the seemingly good intentions, the detectives didn't entirely believe the consternation around the neighborhood. Quite the opposite: they thought people were covering for someone. And so the district attorney had ordered many of the neighbors to be questioned.

I was one of the people they called in to give a statement. I didn't tell Lala, so she wouldn't worry. She hadn't been summoned. It was a very short interview and I didn't say anything that could help them.

I'd slept soundly that night.

No, I hadn't heard anything.

There are street kids in the neighborhood, yes.

The DA showed me the photo of Nachito. I told her I'd never seen him. I wasn't lying. He was completely different from the boys in the neighborhood: a round little boy with dimples and neatly combed hair. I had never seen a boy like that (and smiling!) around Constitución.

No, I never saw black-magic altars in the street or in any of the houses. Only shrines to Gauchito Gil. On Calle Ceballos.

Did I know that Gauchito Gil had practically been decapitated himself, his throat slit? Yes, the whole country knew the legend. I don't think this has to do with Gauchito, do you?

No, of course, you don't have to answer my questions. Well,

anyway, I don't think they're related, but I don't know anything about those rituals.

I work as a graphic designer. For a newspaper. For the supplement "Fashion & Woman." Why do I live in Constitución? It's my family's house and it's a beautiful house; you can see it if you go to the neighborhood.

Of course I'll let you know if I hear anything, sure. Yes, I have trouble sleeping, like everyone. We're very scared.

It was clear I wasn't a suspect, they just had to talk to people in the neighborhood. I went home by bus to avoid the five blocks I'd have to walk if I took the subway. Since the murder I'd avoided the subway because I didn't want to run into the dirty kid. And at the same time, my desire to see him again was obsessive, feverish. In spite of the photos, in spite of the evidence—even the pictures of the corpse, which one newspaper had published to the false outrage and horror of a public that bought up every copy of several editions with the decapitated boy on the front page—I still believed it was the dirty kid who had died.

Or who would be the next to die. It wasn't a rational idea. I told it to Lala at her hair salon the afternoon I went back to dye my tips pink again, a job that took hours. Now no one was flipping through magazines or painting their nails or sending text messages while they waited their turn in Lala's chair. Now they did nothing but talk about the Headless Boy. The time of prudent silence had passed, but I still hadn't heard anyone name a suspect in anything but the most general way. Sarita was telling how once, in Chaco, where she was from, a similar thing had happened, only to a little girl.

"They found her with her head off to one side, too, and very raped, poor little soul. She'd shit all over herself."

"Sarita, please, I'm begging you," said Lala.

"But that's how it was, what do you want me to say? We're talking witches, here."

"The police think they're narcos," I said.

"Witch-narcos are everywhere," said Sarita. "You can't even imagine what it's like out in Chaco. They perform rites to ask for protection. That's why they cut off the head and put it to the left of the body. They think if they make those offerings the police won't catch them, because the heads have power. They're not just narcos, they also traffic women."

"But, you think they're around here, in Constitución?"

"They're everywhere," said Sarita.

I dreamed about the dirty kid. I went out onto the balcony and he was in the middle of the street. I waved my arms at him, trying to get him to move because a truck was barreling toward him. But the dirty kid kept looking up, looking at me and the balcony, smiling, his teeth scummy and small. And the truck ran him over and I couldn't help seeing how the wheel burst his belly open like a soccer ball and then dragged his intestines as far as the corner. In the middle of the street was the dirty kid's head, still smiling, his eyes open.

I woke up sweating and shaking. From the street came the sound of a sleepy *cumbia* rhythm. Little by little, some of the neighborhood's noises were coming back: the drunk fighting, the music, the motorcycles with their rattling exhaust pipes—the local kids liked to loosen them so they'd make a lot of noise. There was a gag order on the investigation, which is to say the confusion was absolute. I visited my mother several times and when she asked me to go live with her, for a while at least, I said no. She called me crazy and we argued, yelling at each other like we never had before.

One night I came home late because, after the office, I'd gone to a colleague's birthday party. It was one of the last days of summer. I took the bus home and got off before my stop so I could take a walk through the neighborhood, alone. By then I knew how to handle myself again. If you know what you're doing, Constitución is easy. I was smoking as I walked. Then I saw her.

The dirty kid's mother was thin; she'd always been thin, even when she was pregnant. From behind, no one would have guessed at the belly she'd had. It's the usual build of addicts: the hips stay narrow like they're refusing to make room for the baby, the body doesn't produce fat, the thighs don't expand. At nine months, the legs are two rickety sticks holding up a basketball, a woman who swallowed a basketball. Now, without her belly, the dirty kid's mother looked more than ever like a teenager as she leaned against a tree, trying to light her crack pipe under the streetlight, unconcerned about the police—who'd been patrolling the neighborhood much more frequently since the Headless Boy's murder—or about other addicts or anything else.

I approached her slowly, and when she saw me, there was immediate recognition in her eyes. Immediate! Her eyes narrowed, squinted: she wanted to run away, but something stopped her. Maybe she was dizzy. Those seconds of doubt were enough for me to block her escape, to stop in front of her, force her to talk. I pushed her against the tree and held her there. She wasn't strong enough to fight back.

"Where is your son?"

"What son? Let me go."

We both spoke quietly.

"Your son. You know very well who I'm talking about."

The dirty kid's mother opened her mouth and it nauseated me to smell her hungry breath, sweet and rotten like fruit left out in the sun, mixed with the medicinal smell of the drug and that burned stench. Addicts smell of burned rubber, of toxic factories, polluted water, chemical death.

"I don't have any kids."

I pressed her harder against the tree, I grabbed her neck. I don't know if she felt pain, but I drove my nails into her. She wouldn't remember me in a few hours anyway. I wasn't afraid of the police either. I knew they wouldn't get too worried over a fight between two women.

"You're going to tell me the truth. You were pregnant until recently."

The dirty kid's mom tried to burn me with her lighter, but I saw her coming, the thin hand that tried to hold the flame to my hair. The bitch wanted to set me on fire. I squeezed her wrist so hard that the lighter fell to the sidewalk. She stopped fighting.

"I DON'T HAVE ANY KIDS!" she yelled at me, and the sound of her voice, too thick, ill, woke me up. What was I doing? Strangling a dying teenager in front of my house? Maybe my mother was right. Maybe I did need to move. Maybe, as everyone had said, I was fixated on that house because it allowed me to isolate myself, because no one visited me there, because I was depressed and I made up romantic stories about a neighborhood that really was just shit, shit, shit. That was what my mother had shouted at me and I swore never to speak to her again, but now, with my hands around the young addict's neck, I thought maybe she wasn't entirely wrong.

Maybe I wasn't the princess in her castle; maybe I was a madwoman locked in her tower.

The junkie girl wiggled out of my hands and started to run, slowly, still choking. But when she got halfway down the block, right where the streetlight shone directly on her, she turned around. She was laughing and in the light you could see her bleeding gums.

"I gave them to *him*!" she shouted.

The words were for me. She was looking me right in the eyes with that horrible recognition. And then she caressed her belly with both hands and said, clearly, loudly:

"This one too. I promised him them both."

I ran toward her, but she was fast. Or she'd suddenly become fast, I don't know. She crossed Plaza Garay like a cat and I went after her, but when the traffic started moving on the avenue, she managed to dodge the cars and make it across and I didn't. I couldn't breathe. My legs were shaking. Someone came up to me and asked if the girl had robbed me and I said yes, hoping they'd chase her. But no. They only asked me if I was OK, if I wanted a taxi, what had she stolen from me.

A taxi, yes, I said. I stopped one and asked the driver to take me to my house, only five blocks away. The driver didn't complain. He was used to that kind of short trip in this neighborhood. Or maybe he just didn't feel like arguing. It was late. It must have been his last fare before heading home.

When I closed the door I didn't feel the relief of the cool rooms, the wooden staircase, the walled garden, the old mosaics and high ceilings. I turned on the light and the lamp flickered: *it's going to go out*, I thought, *I'll be left in the dark*. It steadied, though the light it gave off was yellowish, old, dim. I sat down on the floor with my back against the door. I was waiting to hear the soft taps from the dirty kid's sticky hand, or the sound of his head rolling down the stairs. I was waiting for the dirty kid to ask me, again, to let him in.

"COCKS DON'T TASTE of anything," Auntie Encarna used to say. She'd give you a pat and say: "Bow your head when you want to disappear but keep your chin up the rest of the year, girl." And she was like a mother, like an aunt, to us. Loyalty had a lot to do with why we were all standing around looking at the boy stolen from the Park: Auntie Encarna had taught us how to get by, how to defend ourselves, and how to pretend we were lovable people beaten down by the system, to smile in the supermarket queue, to always say please and thank you, always. And sorry too, very sorry, which is what people like to hear from whores like us.

So, from the moment I met Auntie Encarna, I got used to lying to common folk, saying please and thank you whoever they might be, and sorry too, in all its different incarnations, so people would feel good about themselves and leave you alone for a while.

Every slight lingers like a headache for a few days. A painful migraine that can't be soothed. The insults, the mockery. The heartbreak, the lack of respect. The wheedling of customers, their outright scams, exploitative chongos, submission, idiotically kidding ourselves that we're objects of desire, loneliness, AIDS, broken heels, deaths, murders, internecine feuds over men, gossip, he saids and she saids. It never seemed to end. The beatings, on top of everything else, the beatings the world dealt out to us, in the dark, when you least expected it. The beatings that came immediately after fucking. It'd happened to all of us.

Auntie Encarna said that men's penises were the least important things in the world. That we had our own dangling between our legs and we could always grab them in moments of weakness. She said that we had to work for ourselves, not to pay for whatever the chongo wanted us to spend our money on. And when we slept with a calamity (which is what we called people we slept with for pleasure rather than money), we should make them pay for our bodies in some other way. She also said that after her 178 years on this earth the sorrow had sunk deep. Sometimes she felt as though her legs were like bags of cement, that her organs had petrified and her heart had grown stiff with lack of use. She shed tears over the strictures that kept us down. Like Maria the Mute whom she'd practically brought back to life. When she found her curled up in a dumpster, malnourished and flea-ridden, and taken her home. She had given her a family, the older travestis were her godmothers, the christening was like a neorealist film.

At the age of thirteen, after a week in the pink house, Maria had been christened as a travesti. The ceremony was held on the patio. While everyone was eating nougat and drinking cider, one of the cactus flowers suddenly opened, right in front of everyone, and started to give off a rotten smell that they found deeply unnerving. One of them wondered aloud how a flower could possibly smell like that, while a know-it-all answered that some flowers are pollinated by flies so give off a bouquet of rotten meat to attract them. But that doesn't make them any less beautiful or alluring, and they have the power to silence a group of travestis in the middle of a ritual of christening and loyalty.

This was during our clan's flower period, which flourished in spite of the death sentence that loomed over us. It was a time when we'd sniff each other like dogs and cross-pollinate. The arrival of Twinkle in Her Eye had turned our resentment into a yearning to improve ourselves. Tucu signed up for classes to get her high school diploma: she didn't want to die before she could show it to her mother and say, "Here you go, and I did it all myself, see?" But she was treated so badly at the school where she registered that after her very first day she turned up at the Park bawling her eyes out and started to scream that she was going to fuck around without a condom until she was sick of it. What did it matter, anyway? Auntie Encarna had slapped her silly that night and sent her back to the house to rest. Rest cured all ills. Whether the sickness was one of body or soul, Auntie Encarna always prescribed rest. It was the biggest gift any of us had ever received: letting us sleep while she kept a lookout.

We lived in her orbit. There was always something to eat at her house and we were often hungry. She'd welcome us with open arms and bread on the table. By day I lived the life of a mediocre student. I was poor, I can admit it now, I went hungry. Living off bread alone distorts your body, it makes it sad. Food without color is depressing and demoralizing. But Auntie Encarna's cupboards were always full: if you needed something she'd give it to you. Flour, sugar, oil, maté tea, which was a staple of every home. And she told everyone that another essential was an image of the Virgin of the Valley, who was dark-skinned, rebellious, and powerful enough to change your fate.

WE'D ONLY KNOWN Auntie Encarna to have one real love affair: a quiet, lasting romance with a headless man. Around that time a large number of refugees from African wars arrived in the city. They came to our country with the sand still spilling out of their shoes, saying that they'd

lost their heads in combat. Women went crazy over them for their legendary gentle ways, sensuality, and playfulness. They'd endured plenty of hardships during their wars, suffering almost as much as travestis in the street, and that made them both desirable and heroic. The Headless Men took intensive courses in Spanish so they could speak to us, which was how we learned that having lost their heads, they thought with their entire body, only remembering whatever they'd physically touched. The Headless Men arrived with their novel sweetness and gently let down the women waiting for them with open legs and flaming pussies because they much preferred the travestis of the region. We didn't know why they chose us but a lot of us married and grew old with our decapitated lovers. They explained that they fell in love with us because we were easier to share the trauma with. They could let it climb up the walls or suppress it when necessary. But the women were offended by the snub and started saying sly, malicious things about our guests, men who at the end of the day had fought for a better world. They said that making love with them was like going to the beach, afterward you had sand in your ass for days and days. But we didn't care what they said.

Auntie Encarna met him at Hangar 18, the seediest gay club in the city, the most sacrilegious, Dionysian dive around for dykes, faggots, and queers. The relationship between Encarna and her Headless Man had begun as a very lucrative commercial arrangement, at the time Auntie was taking maximum advantage of her body. Customers didn't take anything out of her. She could sleep with ten men a night, not that that happened very often, and wake up the next day fresh and vigorous as a summer breeze, entangled with her Headless Man, who lived comfortably in his own apartment on a veteran's pension. The Headless Men came from regions that were a mystery to us thanks to our lack of education. We never did learn the causes of the bloody conflicts that had driven them to our city but they were everything a travesti could hope for. Of course, there weren't enough to go around: a lot of them ended up in asylums or decided to move to towns by the sea. But the few who stayed in Córdoba soon settled down and the leak was sealed. Their ageless courtship was an oddity in the life of a travesti. He didn't just love Encarna but everything around her, us included, her honorary daughters. Seeing Auntie Encarna in that man's arms allowed us to hope that someday someone might hug us that way. The Headless Man was the life of all our gatherings and sometimes he'd even invite us to dinner at his apartment. We all went, not just to avoid Auntie Encarna's wrath—she could be more vengeful than the saints and Greek gods put together—but because we wanted to experience his understated hospitality for ourselves, see his watercolors, his feisty dog who slept at the foot of the bed, the endless rows of books on his shelves, which we'd never be able to read even if we did have the time because they were written in a foreign language. I was especially fond of him because one night he saved us, Maria the Mute and I, from right out of the clutches of the police, very close to the pink house. One of them had already started to get violent and had me bent over the car because they'd received reports that a pair of travestis were stealing from the local grocery store. The Headless Man came out of the shadows, approached us in his usual affable manner, spoke to the cops for a couple of minutes, and they let us go. The word of a decapitated man counted for more than anything we might say.

According to Encarna, the Headless Man prayed to his gods before the sun came up with the glorious demeanor of a headless mystic, receiving a fresh injection of life from the first rays of the sun. Then he'd go to the kitchen to put the kettle on as he set out the ingredients for the maté the way his tyrannical girlfriend liked it/a pinch of beebrush, a little peperina mint, the maté leaves (with the dust filtered out), a spoonful of honey, and a twist of orange peel/Then he'd go to the bakery and come back with recently baked medialuna croissants so fresh they fell apart on the tablecloth. He'd always get back at the precise moment the kettle came to the boil for the first maté of the day.

Then he'd go to wake up Auntie Encarna, which was more like rousing her from a fairy-tale curse than sleep. She'd roll around in bed and condescend to be adored: "You're looking beautiful today, my love," were the first words our adoptive mother heard every time she woke up there. And it was enough to block out the horror of the world. A brief spell to banish all thought of day-to-day survival, avoiding death, the deaths of our sisters, other people's misfortunes, which were always ours too. At one point they even announced that they were going to get married and chose me to be the maid of honor. They'd be married by our medicine woman La Machi Travesti, the only person with enough gravitas to officiate at such a ceremony, who provided guidance to our body and soul. She was just as capable of knocking us out with her brews of roots, lianas, and cacti as she was of taking us back to the origins of our pain. She also administered injections of liquid silicon, and all for the same price.

But the wedding plans were postponed, more because of

her than him. She was always trying to save the world, the little, pink travesti world she'd built to encase her loneliness. Auntie Encarna could spend all night sitting in a police station to get one of us out of jail and was just as willing to spend the whole day driving a virus from our body or helping us to remove an ingrown hair on our upper lip. But the love between her and the Headless Man remained strong. He'd visit every Friday afternoon, just when children were coming out of school, so we always associated his arrival with the childish giggles and squeals we heard on the sidewalk. He'd stay until Monday morning and then disappear until the following Friday. On the nights he was with us, when Auntie Encarna had fallen asleep and had begun to snore like a Minotaur, he'd sneak out of her bedroom and sit in the patio if the weather was fair, or the kitchen with the burners on if it was cold. He'd set his headless body to contemplation, because the Headless Man was a born insomniac: it's well known that insomnia is a common affliction in his homeland. We saw him as one of our own, so we took advantage of his kind nature and asked him to help with our makeup before we went out. He always remembered our birthdays and was attentive to our aches and pains.

The Headless Man was also a talented guitar player. We delayed our departure for the Park when he started to play sad songs that made us cry women's tears and wonder why the night was so long. Sometimes Auntie Encarna joined in and sang her tragic songs with gusto. At such times the whole world came to a halt. Extremely dark birds perched on the walls and balconies and we all sat still, not daring to blink or breathe for fear that a false move might break the spell. Seeing the two creatures make music together was like watching them make love, an act so elegant it didn't require privacy.

In the kitchen, a plaster image of the Virgin of Guadalupe looked down at us from the refrigerator, and one of the nights on which we stopped to listen to Auntie Encarna sing accompanied by her boyfriend's guitar, the Holy Guadalupana started to cry along with the song, the tears running down her varnish. We never knew if the miracle was caused by the humidity or a divine manifestation, but whatever it was it was a striking image and our hearts almost burst with the beauty of it. He had obviously been moved too, because a couple of days later he brought a notary to the house and had Auntie Encarna read some important-looking papers in which it was stated that if something were to happen to the Headless Man, his belongings would be passed on to her. We watched Auntie Encarna witnessing the will and couldn't help but notice the ambitious gleam in her eyes, or the grimace of disgust at having to use her male name. We knew all about Auntie Encarna's avarice and the will unsettled us a little. When the notary left and it was only us there, Auntie Encarna announced that she was feeling especially generous and sent out for a bottle of champagne, as though she were celebrating. Just then the TV announced that the iconic drag queen Cris Miró had died and we all gulped and fell silent.

I WAS JUST THIRTEEN, I didn't yet understand what was going on inside me, I couldn't put words to any of it. And then Cris Miró appeared on television. She was on all the most popular shows because she was the first travesti showgirl in Argentina, the first to be recognized by the media. Cris on the grandest sofas of the small screen with the blondest, stupidest, most conservative hosts around. And she was prettier than them all. She had hair down to her waist, black and curly, like a wrinkled rug framing the most beautiful face I had ever seen, a face with a dignity, peace, and friendliness inconceivable on the frightful television landscape of the time. And so I learned of the existence of travestis. I was just a child when I first saw her on TV but I immediately knew that I wanted to be like her. That was what I wanted for myself. The uncertainty of transvestism, the disorientation of the office. The epiphany was such that in spite of all the obstacles in my way I too let my hair grow long, chose a woman's name, and from then on kept my ears open to the siren call of my vocation. We all admired her, we all loved her. She was an example. She was the best of us on display for all to see. So news of her death depressed and silenced us. We couldn't stomach Auntie Encarna's champagne: our Evita, our model and guiding light, the most famous and best of us all, had died. No one spoke, no one knew what to say about someone dying so young. But our shared gazes said everything. How absurd that on the same day that Auntie Encarna was named the Headless Man's heir, such sad news was announced to the world. I still remember that silence and what La Boliviana said from the back of the patio: she didn't like Cris at all. She had a very square jaw, she said. We all told her to shut up in unison. To get out of our sight.

WHEN THE BOY CAME to the boardinghouse, things started to change between Auntie Encarna and her Headless Man. We thought that now we had our own Jesus, Mary, and Joseph, our own holy family, a family that reflected us, and we were their daughters. We couldn't think of a better father for the boy than the Headless Man: men like him came from far away, they knew stories, they told you what you wanted to know about the world. They were the occasions one is so grateful for in the monotonous life of a prostitute. The Headless Men who brought suitcases full of recipes for exotic dishes, medicinal plants, new ways of planting in water and the air. New ways to love. Men like him taught us foreign languages, they

had moves we'd never experienced before, they made our skin feel thin as crepe paper, as though we'd turned transparent, as though suddenly God could see right inside of us.

But Auntie Encarna started to get brusque. She began to sabotage the Headless Man's visits, allowing the monster inside of her to lash out with poisonous comments about his generosity, freedom, the exaggerated kindness with which he treated us, as though we were all his girlfriends. Who did he think he was? Had he forgotten that he'd been a john, that he'd paid for her?

The first time that the Headless Man tried to pick up Twinkle in Her Eye, Encarna looked him up and down and declared that no child of hers was going to be held by someone without a head. Maria the Mute, who happened to be there, read her lips and scolded her instantly. But Auntie Encarna had located her character, she knew from whence her water flowed and she wasn't ready to turn off the spigot. The Headless Man, friendly to the last, simply backed away to the door and asked what they needed, he had contacts that could help out if she wanted to adopt the child officially and once the wars were over he'd take them both to his home country, Auntie Encarna and Twinkle in Her Eye, to eat the fruit from the baobab tree that fed the Headless Men. It was what made them sweet as honeycombs.

In reply, all he got was insults, attacks, unfounded claims, and mockery of his good nature. But he refused to snap. He put up with it and put up with it and put up with it. Until one afternoon Auntie Encarna decided not to open the door and forbade the women of the family from saying a word to him on pain of exile, excommunication, banishment—there would be no exceptions for such a betrayal. The Headless Man stood for a couple of days under the lamppost on the sidewalk opposite. Then he left without saying a word and we never saw him again. Some of us, feeling sorry for him, would drop by his house hoping to find him with his apron on, making the delicious treats he cooked only for us, but no.

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